

Skin Across a Lifetime

Intrinsic and extrinsic ageing, hormonal seasons, and the grace of a skin that is allowed to change

Learning Objectives

- Distinguish intrinsic ageing from extrinsic ageing, with real examples
- Describe how collagen and elastin decline over time and what genuinely helps
- Identify the skin changes common to adolescence, pregnancy, and menopause
- Speak about ageing skin with the reverence Amber requires, never with alarm

Two very different clocks

Consider two people, both fifty. The first has smooth skin with only fine lines beneath her eyes — a gift from her mother's genes. The second, a lifelong sailor under open sun for decades, carries deep wrinkles and pronounced sun spots. Both are ageing. Neither is ageing "wrong."

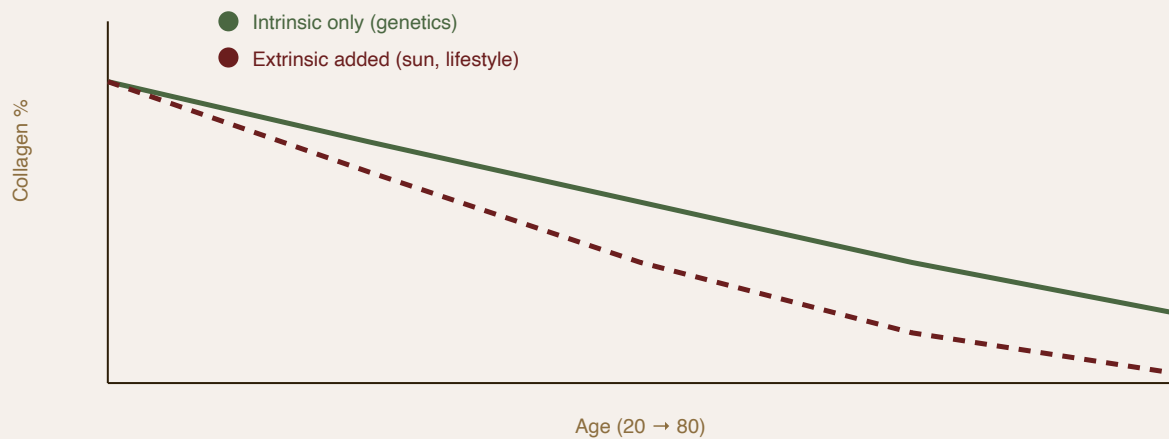
- **Intrinsic ageing** — genetically programmed, ticking regardless of environment: gradual thinning, reduced elasticity, fine lines.
- **Extrinsic ageing** — driven by external factors: UV radiation above all, pollution, smoking, lifestyle. This is the ageing a good routine can genuinely influence.

You cannot stop the clock. You can, with real skill, slow the hands that are moving faster than they need to.

What actually happens beneath the surface

As skin ages, collagen and elastin begin to degrade. Collagen content declines by roughly 1% per year after age twenty. This is why **vitamin C** (supports synthesis, fights free radicals) and **retinoids** (boost collagen production) matter so much here.

◆ Figure 8.1 · Intrinsic vs. Extrinsic Ageing



Collagen decline over a lifetime — gentler with intrinsic ageing alone, steeper when extrinsic factors compound it.

The hormonal seasons of skin

- **Adolescence.** Rising androgens increase oil production, often bringing the first acne — a normal, temporary chapter.
- **Pregnancy.** Hormonal shifts can bring a "glow," but also melasma and heightened sensitivity — many strong actives, including retinoids, are avoided during this season.
- **Menopause.** Declining oestrogen accelerates collagen loss and often brings new dryness to skin that was oily for decades.



The Origin BubbleJapan · Wabi-sabi · The honoured line

The Bowl That Was Broken, and Made More Beautiful

In old Japan, when a treasured ceramic bowl cracked, it was mended with *kintsugi* — lacquer mixed with powdered gold, filling the crack until the break became the most beautiful line on the bowl. The philosophy beneath it, *wabi-sabi*, is the reverence of imperfection and the visible marks of a life fully lived.

Japanese grandmothers carried this to their own skin. The evening ritual was quiet, unhurried care: warm water, a soft cloth, rice bran, and camellia oil worked into skin that had earned every line it carried.

This is not a philosophy of neglect. The skin was cared for meticulously, daily, for decades. It is a philosophy of honesty — care without the demand that the years disappear.

The reflection

Wabi-sabi does not oppose good skincare science — it reframes its purpose. A well-cared-for ageing skin is not a skin restored to a younger version of itself, but a life, tended with dignity.

The standard you will hold: Offer every genuine, evidence-based tool this course teaches — and never speak of ageing as a problem to be feared. Amber sells skin health, never shame.

Key Terms

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[object Object]

1

[object Object]

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Practical Activity · The Two Clocks

Reflect on someone over forty's skin changes across their life. Identify which changes were likely intrinsic and which extrinsic, and any hormonal seasons they describe. Write a short, kind reflection on how you would speak with them about their skin.